

CONSTITUTION
OF
REFORMED UNIVERSITY FELLOWSHIP (RUF)

In order to better regulate the affairs of the organization, and to render the most efficient service in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ on the campus of Furman University, the following constitution has been established.

Article 1: NAME

Section 1. The name of the organization shall be REFORMED UNIVERSITY FELLOWSHIP (RUF).

Section 2. This organization is a ministry of the Presbyterian Church in America (PCA) to the students, faculty, and staff of Furman University.

Article 2: PURPOSE, GOALS, & PRINCIPLES

Section 1. The purpose of this organization is to glorify God by reaching students for Christ and equipping students to serve. This is accomplished through large group meetings for praise and worship as well as instruction from the Bible, small group studies, and one-on-one meetings.

Section 2. The goals of this organization include growth in grace, fellowship and service, evangelism and missions, and a Biblical world and life view.

Paragraph 1. According to the Scriptures, it is the responsibility and privilege of every Christian to conform and be conformed to the image of Jesus Christ (growth in grace). Therefore, we seek to learn what God has revealed in His Word concerning what we are to believe and what God requires of us.

Paragraph 2. According to the Scriptures, it is the responsibility and privilege of every Christian to foster caring and edifying relationships with other Christians, and to show concern and mercy to any who are in need (fellowship and service). Therefore, we seek (1) to provide an atmosphere for Christian fellowship, and (2) to identify areas for Christian service.

Paragraph 3. According to the Scriptures, it is the responsibility and privilege of Christians to proclaim the Gospel of Jesus Christ, both locally and globally. Therefore, we seek to be firmly grounded in the Scriptures in order to accurately teach its message to others, to understand the Gospel and be prepared to answer questions and challenges to the Christian message, and to seek opportunities both locally and globally to participate in the spreading of the Gospel (evangelism and missions).

Paragraph 4. According to the Scriptures, it is the responsibility and privilege of every Christian to be transformed by the renewing of his/her mind by the Word of God. Therefore, we seek to be continually reforming, understanding that all of life – whether culturally, educationally, religiously, economically, or socially, etc. – are to be seen through the eyes of Scripture.

Section 3. The principles by which this organization operates include the sufficiency of Scripture alone which tells us about the Gospel of Jesus Christ (justification and sanctification).

Paragraph 1. We believe the Scriptures of the Old and New Testaments were verbally inspired by Almighty God and are the authoritative Word of God. Therefore, we hold that the Bible is the only infallible rule of faith and practice.

Paragraph 2. We believe that Reformed theology as set forth in the Westminster Confession of Faith and Catechisms is the system of doctrine taught in Scripture, and therefore, is to be taught, learned, and proclaimed for the edification and government of Christians, for the propagation of the Christian faith, and for the evangelization of the world by the power of the Gospel of our Lord Jesus Christ.

Paragraph 3. We believe that Jesus Christ was God's provision for His people's separation from God because of their sin. The same God who requires perfect righteousness is the same God who provides that righteousness to those who by faith embrace the Lord Jesus Christ. The fact that there is now no condemnation for those who are united to Christ is Good News (Gospel) to those who understand that they have no righteousness of their own to offer to God.

Paragraph 4. We believe this Gospel answers the two most fundamental questions that a person can ask: (1) How can a person be made right with God? (Justification); and (2) How can a person change to become more of what God designed him/her to be? (Sanctification)

Article III: **GOVERNMENT**

- Section 1. The oversight of the organization shall be by the advisor and the RUF campus minister, working with a group of students existing as the Leadership.
- Section 2. The advisor and the Campus Minister have the final responsibility to see that the Leadership and the group at large are functioning according to the organization's purpose and objectives.
- Section 3. The current RUF Campus Minister is the Rev. JR Foster (864.434.0334/ jfoster@ruf.org). The current advisor is Dr. Brent Nelsen (brent.nelsen@furman.edu).

Article IV: **MEMBERSHIP**

- Section 1. The organization shall be primarily a fellowship of Christian students and secondarily a place where others can investigate what Christianity teaches. There will be no process for membership since association with RUF is voluntary. Association with RUF is open to all students and faculty / staff interested in the purpose, goals, and principles of the organization. We are here for the convinced and unconvinced.
- Section 2. Procedures for disciplining and/or removing members. Since RUF is a strictly voluntary association open to any who are willing to explore the teachings of Christianity or fellowship with other believers, there is no membership per se. All who come to RUF to participate in worship and to learn through our weekly large group meeting are admonished to follow the Scriptural teaching regarding unity as stated in Ephesians 4:2-3, "Be completely humble and gentle; be patient, bearing with one another in love. Make every effort to keep the unity of the Spirit through the bond of peace."

It is the desire of RUF that all who associate with RUF will conduct themselves in a manner worthy of the Gospel of Christ (Philippians 1:27). The nature of our organization is ministerial and for mutual encouragement; however, there may be rare occasions where those associations openly with RUF may not fall in line with the stated purposes, goals, and principles of RUF. The core group may address this issue with the individual during which he/she will have opportunity to share his or her perspective. Issues of consequence will be referred to the campus minister and/or advisor who may contact university

officials or the civil magistrate at his discretion if behaviors warrant such outside help.

Article V. **OFFICERS**

Section 1. Requirements.

The officers of this organization must meet the following requirements:

- (a) Be in good standing with the university and enrolled.

Section 2. Duties.

President: shall preside over executive meetings, coordinate group activities in conjunction with the Leadership, and communicate with the officers, advisor, and campus staff worker on all matters.

Vice-President: shall assist president and preside over meetings in the absence of the president.

Treasurer: shall oversee any monetary transactions such as fund-raising and/or funds for social activities which has been deemed by the Leadership as necessary to collect.

Secretary: shall coordinate publicity and recruitment as well as record minutes at executive meetings and attendance.

It is expected by the RUF group at large, the Leadership, the RUF campus minister and the advisor that those who hold office in this student organization shall be exemplary in their lives and ethics and should strive to set an example for others to follow in word and deed.

Section 3. Officer Selection Process

The current officers and Leadership in consultation with the Campus Minister and/or faculty advisor will nominate candidates in the spring semester from within RUF to represent RUF as the next officers. These nominations will be presented to RUF at large for approval. Simple

majority vote by a show of hands of those attending will be sufficient to elect the officers.

Section 4. Officer Removal

If for any reason the elected officers fail to meet any of the requirements outlined above (specifically, compliance with University requirements or failure to carry out assigned duties), the officer board will notify the officer of the failure. The officer will be given opportunity to explain the situation and/or share his/her perspective. In the case of failing to comply with University requirements, the officer will be asked to step down in order to fulfill these requirements. In the meantime, nominations by the officer board will be given and election by simple majority of RUF at large group will be obtained.

Article VI: **AMENDING THE CONSTITUTION**

Section 1. The Constitution shall be amended by the Leadership in conjunction with the advisor and the RUF Campus Minister at their discretion.

Section 2. The adoption of amendments to or changes of the Constitution shall require a two-thirds vote by the Leadership after consultation with the advisor and the RUF Campus Minister. All amendments and/or changes are subject to the approval of the Director of Student Activities.

Section 3. This document is to be reviewed every year and resubmitted.

BY-LAWS OF REFORMED UNIVERSITY FELLOWSHIP

Article I: **GOVERNMENT**

Section 1. The Leadership shall be composed of a minimum of three students and a maximum of twenty.

Section 2. The Leadership shall choose one of its members to act as Chairman of its meetings.

Section 3. The Leadership shall be self-perpetuating in that the advisor and RUF Campus Minister, in conjunction with the Core Group, shall seek those who are to make up the Leadership.

Article II: **MEMBERSHIP**

Section 1. No dues or fees are a prerequisite for membership. Membership is not required since RUF operates as a voluntary association of Christian fellowship on the campus.

Article III: **TIME AND PLACE OF MEETING**

Section 1. The time and place of meetings will be determined by the Leadership in conjunction with the advisor and RUF Campus Minister.

Section 2. A quorum shall consist of fifty percent plus one (50% + 1) of the membership and must be present to conduct official business. This will look like a simple majority of those who come to the regular at large meetings of RUF since membership in RUF is defined as a voluntary association.

Article IV: **AMENDING THE BY-LAWS**

Section 1. The by-laws shall be amended by the Leadership in conjunction with the advisor and the RUF Campus Minister at their discretion.

Section 2. The adoption of amendments to or changes of the Constitution shall require a two-thirds vote by the Leadership after consultation with the advisor and the RUF Campus Minister.

Section 3. This document is to be reviewed every year and resubmitted to the Department of Student Activities.

Article V: **ADVISORS**

Section 1. Expectations

- (a) The advisor to RUF shall be a Furman University employee. The advisor will be willing to obtain an appropriate level of experience, resource information and knowledge related to the mission, purpose and activities of the association.
- (b) The advisor will be available for consultation outside of Leadership meetings. The advisor will be available to attend both Leadership meetings as well as our weekly general large group meetings.

Section 2. Replacement

- (a) If for any reason the advisor is no longer willing and/or able to fulfill the responsibilities, he/she will formally communicate this to the student organization and in writing. The organization will then determine the appropriate course of action for replacing the advisor.

Who We Are

Reformed University Fellowship (RUF) is the campus ministry of the Presbyterian Church in America (PCA). Though we exist on campus through the PCA, you will find students from a wide variety of backgrounds here at Furman University, because we welcome students from any and all walks of life. We are here for the "convinced" and the "unconvinced." It is our aim to "reach students for Christ and equip them to serve in His church."

Why Reformed?

The word "reformed" identifies our perspective--we operate from a Biblical worldview that is rooted in the rich tradition of the Protestant Reformation. Our teaching and ministry are informed by reformed theology, including a commitment to faith in Jesus Christ as the only means of salvation. Contrary to the idea that "truth" is relative or unknowable, Christianity stands upon very clear and specific truth claims. Jesus taught that we must believe who he claimed to be and hold to his teachings. Our ministry is set up in such a way that students are given opportunities to wrestle with the truth (through the Bible--God's word), and to see that the gospel speaks to every need and every area of life. Through exposure to truth, we hope that many will come to know the One who is truth, Jesus Christ. Also, we believe that Christianity is not just a moral system. It does contain a moral system, but that is not the heart of what it means to be a Christian. Rather than simply becoming a better person, the gospel makes you a new person. It brings new life for those who are dead in sin, and brings hope for the hopeless. We believe that those who come to see that Jesus is the truth will also see that He is life.

Why the University?

Jesus said, "I am making all things new!" RUF was born out of a desire not to abandon the college campus, nor to be lost in it. It is the dream of RUF to be a ministry for our campus, not for ourselves. This hope is founded in the belief that the gospel can change any person and any place. Our leading question is not "what kind of ministry can we be?" but rather "what kind of university can this be?" Our hope is that the power and beauty of Christ will transform university people and institutions.

Why Fellowship?

The Christian faith is not something that can be lived out alone. The Christian is called to live within community--the Church. We face our struggles together; we taste the life of heaven together. RUF is committed to building up and inviting people into this unique and loving community. The glory of the church is not her people, however. Her glory is her Redeemer, Christ the Lord! Because Christ loved the church, and gave himself up for her, we are then delighted to gather under her care. It is here that God is at work, gathering his people, and strengthening them for the work of his kingdom.

What we Believe

In the transformational power of the gospel

The message of the gospel is that Christ has done what is necessary to bring us into a relationship with God. That means that our sinfulness does not count against us and it also means that our religious efforts don't count for us. The good news is that Christ hasn't given us a philosophy or list of rules to follow, but that he has given us Himself, and that His life of perfect obedience is credited to all that repent and believe.

In the truth and authority of Scripture

We not only believe that the Scriptures are true, but that through them God is "at work in those who believe" (1 Thessalonians 2:13). It is also through the Scripture that God changes the hearts of those unconvinced of the truth of the gospel. Therefore, the Bible isn't just to be held in high regard, it is to be used in every aspect of life.

In the Church

The Christian faith is not something that can be lived out alone. The Christian is called to live within community--the Church. We face our struggles together, we taste the life of heaven together. But the glory of this distinct community is not her people. Her glory is her redeemer, Christ the Lord! Because Christ loved the church and gave Himself up for her we are then delighted to gather under her care. RUF is a ministry of the Presbyterian Church in America and adheres to its confessional standards.

In kingdom responsibility

The church is the institution through which God is building His kingdom and is renewing every aspect of life. Every Christian has a unique calling and a unique giftedness to serve others in his or her community. Christians should demonstrate this by serving others and working with excellence, for God's glory, in all that they do. That God is at work. Our great confidence is that Jesus said that He would build His church. Our hope is not in ourselves and our abilities, but in the goodness and grace of God. We are not called to "get things started", but rather to recognize and participate in what God is already doing in our city. That the gospel changes people and places. While the historic message of Christianity is unchanging, the context of our ministry constantly changes. But in any context, we believe that the gospel speaks to the whole person, whether religious or irreligious, and that it can transform any place, bringing the healing and restoration of Christ's Kingdom. Jesus said, "I am making all things new!" Reformed University Fellowship (RUF) is the campus ministry of the Presbyterian Church in America (PCA). Though we

exist on campus through the PCA, you will find students from a wide variety of backgrounds here at Furman University, because we welcome students from any and all walks of life. We are here for the "convinced" and the "unconvinced." It is our aim to "reach students for Christ and equip them to serve in His church."

What Sets Us Apart

A typical university will have several Christian ministries represented on campus. An important question is, what makes RUF distinctive? Our distinctives are found in the following commitments:

A Commitment To: The Visible Church

RUF ministries are not to replace the church. We are the church going to the campus. Essential to our ministry is a commitment and accountability to the visible church. It is of first importance in our practice and teaching. The church is never seen as merely a useful means to grow, but rather it is seen as God's ordained institution by which the gospel is proclaimed and Christians become more like Christ. It is in the context of the church that all the means by which we grow are available. It is to the church that Christ has given the task of evangelism and discipleship.

A Commitment To: In-Depth Bible Study

At RUF we believe in having fun, but also that the quality of our fun and relationships as a group will be better, more mature, and more fulfilling when our lives are being transformed and seriously affected by a real encounter with all of God's Word. We believe that college students are ready for and interested in knowing God deeply.

A Commitment To: The Student's Vocation

The vocation of university student is just that - a university student. RUF takes that seriously and strives to equip students to be faithful and growing Christians who are conscientious in their studies. The campus is not reduced to a convenient pretext to do evangelism, but rather the place where God has providentially placed students to prepare for legitimate vocations after graduation. Christians learn, grow and reach others in the midst of this, not in spite of it. Our activities and expectations always seek to be consistent with this view.

A Commitment To: Emphasizing Being Rather Than Doing

RUF ministries will have a variety of activities on the schedule, but we do not expect everyone to be involved in everything. We have no agenda to involve students in a crush of activities, something that often burns them out. Rather, our goal is to help students become people who truly know God, and whose lives are profoundly affected because of it. This, rather than a flurry

of activities, is what we believe people (especially students) need. And we believe that it is only this, more than techniques and memorized methods, which will make their life and witness more effective and authentic.

A Commitment To: Challenge and Think

We believe in absolute truth, and we also believe the most helpful thing we can do for people is to help them learn to recognize and discover that truth themselves. We avoid giving a set of pat, canned answers. We encourage thoughtful questions and place a strong emphasis on critical thinking, learning how to interpret and understand the Bible properly, and then applying it to all of life today. Christianity is a way of seeing all of life. We believe that God is at work in the world, upholding his creation and ruling over all his creatures. His revealed truth is the integrating principle for all knowledge. This provides the Christian with a frame of reference for thinking and life-style.